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Exploring Depression and Identity through the visual novel “J in the Gray Room”

Introduction

The game prototype 'J in the Gray Room' offers a unique exploration of identity, with a specific focus on mental health disorders, such as depression. Developed using RenPy, a visual novel engine, the game prioritizes a narrative-driven experience to convey its underlying themes. Firstly, this paper aims to explore the concept of identity within the context of creating interactive media. Additionally, it will delve into the connection between mental health and identity, as well as the role of gender in discussions surrounding mental health. Finally, we will discuss the development process of the game prototype and explore how these themes are realized throughout its implementation.

Representing Identity

When attempting to portray the abstract concepts associated with identity through a piece of media, it is essential to reflect on the understanding of both our personal identity, as well as the broader definition of the concept. This reflection is particularly crucial for game developers who are responsible for representing characters with diverse identities, especially in narrative-driven games. By analyzing how we choose to express our own identity, we can take the initial step towards empathizing with people with identities different from our own. It is also vital to consider which specific aspects of our identity we intend to represent within the medium. Additionally, it is essential to make sure that the way in which we represent these ideas is done in a respectful and appropriate manner. There have been some successful representations of mental disorders in video games, some examples include *Hellblade Senua's Sacrifice* (Ninja Theory 2017), *Celeste* (Maddy Makes Games 2018), as well as some lesser-known independent titles like *Adventures with Anxiety* (Case 2019). However, despite these well-crafted examples, the overall lack of representation, as well as the misrepresentation of mental illness by some well-known titles (e.g., *Outlast* (Red Barrels 2013)), shows that there is still a need for proper destigmatized representation.

Mental Health and Identity

Before exploring the relationship between mental health and identity, it is important to establish a general understanding of the concept of identity. According to Kathryn Woodward (Woodward 2012), the way we define identity is shaped by recognizing and embracing our differences, as we navigate the world and determine our place in it. Although mental health may

not be the obvious topic when it comes to identity representation, I believe that examining this connection can offer valuable and unique insights.

Identity is a dynamic concept that changes and evolves just as our understanding of ourselves does. It holds particular significance during adolescence, a period characterized by self-exploration and the establishment of one's identity. Adolescence marks a phase in which people begin to compare themselves to their peers and gain an understanding of their unique qualities and differences, laying the foundation for identity formation. This process in itself can be complicated and confusing, but for adolescents that experience struggles with mental health, this process becomes all the more challenging.

Depression is a mental health disorder characterized by persistent feelings of sadness, loss of interest in activities, changes in appetite or sleep patterns, low energy levels, and difficulty in carrying out daily functions, often accompanied by feelings of worthlessness or guilt (World Health Organization 2023). It is a serious disorder that can affect all aspects of an individual's life. People who suffer from depression often experience a lack of motivation to do everyday tasks and an overall unwillingness to participate in activities that they once enjoyed. They may also isolate themselves, finding social interactions draining, even avoiding close friends and family. From an external perspective, it may appear that the depressed individual has become a "different person". Subsequently, the person experiencing depression may express similar feelings, noticing the drastic difference in their behavior and personality. Indeed, a substantial part of our identity is shaped by our hobbies, interests, relationships, as well as our goals and ambitions. When these fundamental parts of ourselves undergo a change, the way we view ourselves is affected as well.

Adolescence is a crucial period characterized by the development of meaningful relationships, the formation of a personal point of view, and exploration of various hobbies and interests. However, when an individual experiences a mental disorder such as depression during this transformative phase, it can drastically hinder their personal growth and their journey of self-discovery. Moreover, it can have detrimental long-lasting effects on a perception of their identity. This particular topic is the core idea behind the 'J in the Gray Room' prototype. The subsequent sections of this paper will delve into how this idea is incorporated into the game.

Mental Health and Gender

The way that adolescents experience depression and other mental disorders can vary depending on their gender. Research suggests that there are notable gender differences in the prevalence of depression among adolescents. For instance, studies have indicated that adolescent girls tend to exhibit higher rates of depression compared to boys (Girgus and Yang 2015). This difference may be partially attributed to the correlation between biological, hormonal, and social factors. Adolescent girls often face unique challenges related to gender socialization, body image, and societal expectations, which can contribute to their increased vulnerability to depression.

Moreover, people outside of the gender binary (e.g., non-binary, gender-fluid, trans people, etc.) may face further unique challenges. Research has indicated higher rates of depression among non-binary and transgender adolescents compared to cisgender individuals. Several studies have

examined mental health disparities and found that trans youth are at increased risk for depression compared to their cisgender counterparts (Reisner et al. 2015).

These findings indicate that gender is not only an integral aspect of a person's identity, but it also has a drastic impact on the mental health of adolescents. Although gender does not play a primary role in the game prototype, future iterations of the game will incorporate these ideas further.

‘J in the Gray Room’: Plot, Themes, and Further Development

The prototype ‘J in the Gray Room’ is dealing with topics of mental illness and how it can affect a person's sense of identity. More specifically focusing on the effect of depression on an adolescent girl. The game's goal is to provide representation for people struggling with mental illnesses as well as to give an educational opportunity for people who want to learn more about these issues.

The plot centers around a young girl who finds herself in a colorless and unfamiliar place known as the Gray Room. Struggling with amnesia, she is unable to remember her identity except for the initial letter of her name, ‘J.’ In the Gray Room, she encounters a mysterious character named A.J., who takes on the role of her guide and helps her restore her lost memories. Through their interactions, J is exposed to significant moments from her past, including her friendships and hobbies. In the end, J manages to restore her memories and regain some of the color that she had previously lost. The game can be seen as a journey of self-rediscovery and describes the process of regaining one's identity after the battle with depression.

Since ‘J in the Gray Room’ is a visual novel, the mechanics of the game are representative of the narrative-based and choice-driven mechanics usually found in interactive fiction games and visual novels. The plot follows a linear structure to tell the story of J and her rediscovery of herself. However, this mechanics model is specific to the prototype, as the intention for future iterations of the game is to develop a more dynamic and adaptive gameplay experience.

Further development of the game will include the incorporation of generative AI (e.g., a large language model such as ChatGPT (see OpenAI 2022)) to adapt parts of the story to reflect the player's personal experience. For instance, a part of the game is dedicated to J attempting to recall the memories related to her love of playing guitar. Together with A.J., they reflect on the way J's depression has warped those memories. The goal of this section is for J, and subsequently for the player, to reflect on their hobbies as part of their identities. Additionally, to reflect on the way depression can create a sense of apathy for things that once brought us joy. The narrative effect of identifying with the main character of the story alone can serve as a powerful tool for relaying ideas to players. However, the message might come across all the stronger, if instead of J's hobby, the player gets to reminisce about their own perhaps forsaken hobby. One possible way to achieve this is through a dedicated character creator. Before the game begins, the player will be given a chance to fill in some information about their character or themselves, if they prefer. This information (e.g., their gender, hobbies, vocation, etc.) will be given to the language model that will adapt the narrative accordingly.

The gender of the character doesn't play an evident role in the prototype, however in the future iterations of the game when players will be able to choose the gender of their character, I believe it will be beneficial to have this choice reflected in the narrative of the game by including the findings from the studies mentioned in the 'Mental health and Gender' section of this paper. The main themes of the game include the representation of color as it reflects (the loss of) identity and the relationship with one's inner child.

In the game, color is an integral tool to reflect J's memory loss, as well as the perceived loss of her identity. The Gray Room represents the way a person with depression views the outside world: colorless and bleak. Initially, J herself lacks any color as can be seen in Figure 1. When A.J. shows J some photos from her past, the color of the Gray Room fluctuates depending on J's mental state. Throughout the game, J is supposed to regain her color as she regains her memories. However, at the end of the story, a piece of gray hair remains, symbolizing the toll that mental illness takes on a person that may never fully heal or go away (Figure 2). Memory loss in general is a common occurrence in people suffering from trauma and/or depression (Smith 2018).



Figure 1 — J at the beginning of the game



Figure 2 — J at the end of the game

Depression stemming from trauma is another possible future exploration to be added to the game. The first concept I made shown in Figure 3 depicts the color going out of J as a result of experiencing trauma. Depending on the development of the game with the addition of a player-adaptive narrative, the way the main character ‘loses their color’ can also be player-dependent.

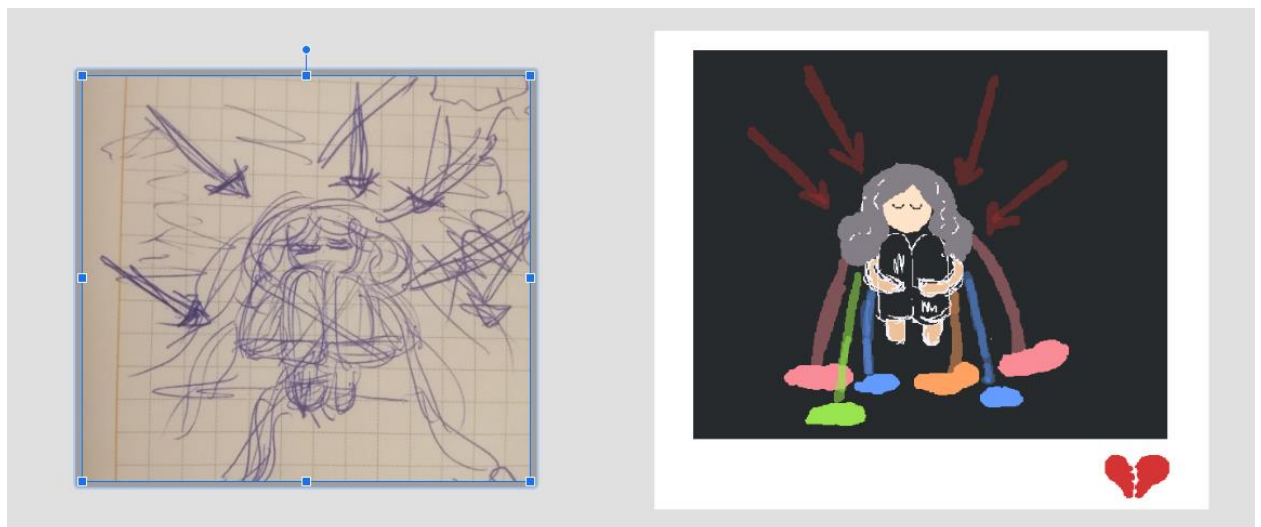


Figure 3 — Concept of J ‘losing color’ due to experiencing trauma

The concept of inner child healing in therapy is rooted in the belief that everyone has an "inner child" that represents their past experiences, emotions, and unmet needs from childhood.

Inner child healing aims to address and heal the traumas and unresolved issues from one's childhood by reconnecting with this inner child aspect of oneself. It involves creating a safe space for exploration, validation, and healing of past experiences, allowing people to develop self-compassion and emotional growth. The game explores the concept of the “inner child” healing through the relationship between A.J. and J (with ‘A’ standing for Adult J). Exploring this relationship can be beneficial to players from two perspectives. Firstly, the prototype offers players an opportunity to explore and process their childhood traumas and negative memories, enabling them to reflect on a time in their lives when they may have been too young or lacked the capacity to fully acknowledge and process their emotions. Secondly, within the prototype, players can develop a meaningful relationship with a supportive figure and mentor, addressing the void they may have experienced during adolescence. This relationship serves as a valuable source of support and guidance, not only for players who lacked such support in their past but also for adolescent players seeking guidance and support in their present lives.

Conclusion

This paper, along with the accompanying game prototype, aims to offer a distinct perspective on the interplay between identity, mental health, and adolescence. The game prototype builds on the research discussed in this paper, focusing primarily on mental health and identity theory. Given the sensitive nature of the themes explored in the prototype, it is important to incorporate expert feedback before its public release. In conclusion, the topic of mental illness remains highly relevant, and increasing representation and visibility around this issue are crucial for providing much-needed support for people from all walks of life.

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